

e019-loretta-afraid-of-bear-cook-living-in-oglala-lakota-community

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Welcome to the Domination Chronicles podcast. I'm your co-host, Peter P. d'Errico.

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And I'm your co-host, Steven Newcomb. Together, Peter and I have 90 years of experience researching,

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discussing, and writing about indigenous people's issues. Here, we explore themes such as the

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original free existence of Native nations and peoples, colonization as a claim of a right of

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domination, and civilization as a process and system of domination. Be sure to like and subscribe to our

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Now let's get into it.

[Peter] (0:03 - 0:36)

Good morning, Steve, and good morning, Loretta Afraid of Bear-Cook. I'm wonderful to meet you here. What I'd like to do since you and Steve have known each other and worked together for so long is just sit back and listen for a while.

And I know what we'd like is you talk for a while, just talk about what you're doing, where you've come from, and whatever you feel like saying. But Steve and you working together, I figure Steve will probably have some maybe specific questions for you. So anyway, good morning.

Take it away.

[Steve] (0:37 - 1:26)

Right. Well, good morning, Peter, and good morning, Loretta. This is our podcast, Domination Chronicles, and it's so good to have you here.

And it's really an honor to have you as a guest. And I have such admiration for you because you have been raised traditionally in your language and with your traditions and have done so much to dedicate your life to upholding those Wolakota traditions. And so maybe it would be best if you introduce yourself and just feel free to discuss however you want to introduce yourself and however you want to open the discussion and conversation.

[Loretta] (1:28 - 7:15)

Thank you, Steve. Thank you so much. Thank you, Peter, for inviting me to be on your podcast today.

I have to say that sometimes I lapse into my own language as I'm talking English. So you might get a bit of that. And for me, first and foremost, in the nation's house, I'm told to announce who I am.

And I am Umpetulutawi. And in that sense, well, you see the dawn coming and there's a red that comes in front of the daytime and the night is leaving. And that red stripe that comes, that's what my name means.

And so I do all of my precious, important work that's setting down to be in service in that realm of it, in the daytime of each day. So we're brought up being told to understand our place, to steward, to do and understand what it is around us that can be running smoothly in a community. And so when I was born in 1947, in the wintertime, there were 14 of us born right around the same time period.

So our community had an influx of 14 new babies right around Thanksgiving and Christmas and in the coming of the new year and that. So we all started out together. And to me, we had traditional midwives and traditional doulas that came and waited on each other, all the mothers-in-law, sisters-in-law, daughters, the women, they all knew to wait on each other.

And that was an important concept in our community because that's how the wheel turned to be able to affect good things happening in that community and keeping things intact. So those of us running around in the community always had, somebody was always feeding us or taking care of us. And so I grew up with that concept of community always at the heart of everything.

And so in everything I try to do, I try to base it that way. Whether I'm living in a new community, I find a place where

I can fit in and to help and to be always in service. But my grandparents, I was a month old.

My birthday was the 22nd of November and I turned a month old around the time of solstice. And my grandparents were so proud to be grandpa and grandma that they went out and bought gifts for the entire community and they butchered a couple of cows and they had the big celebration where because we're kept home for a month, they don't let us come out. We were presented to the community at that Christmas time, solstice time.

And so we had an upbringing like that. Some of us right from the get-go were presented and there's certain protocols that are affected. And we grew up knowing about those things.

We grew up knowing about when to talk and when not to. So it was a really familiar, safe community for me growing up. We had gardens.

My grandparents had big gardens. The community would come and have to plant and the little kids, we'd have to carry buckets of water out to the gardens to water our gardens because we didn't have running water. But we had all of that.

My grandparents had cattle, they had horses, they had pigs, they had goats, they had everything. And so we hardly ever got to go to town. So my influence about running to town to just get one or two little things, it just didn't exist back in the day.

I never, even during school year when we had vacation, I never did go to town during the summertime. The only time I got to go was when I was coming home from school and we drove through town. And then the other time was when we were going into town to get me new school clothes to go back to school.

So I had the whole summertime to interact with my own community. And so growing up in that way, it was just celebration of marriages, whatever that our people were doing. We had our local medicine man in our community.

My grandmother that caught me or delivered me, the midwife was the medicine man's wife Grandma Jenny. And so those concepts about being grounded became very much appreciated by myself when I began to grow up and then come into a larger time. I kept close to the traditional ways.

I stayed close to that and was always looking for people who I could interact with or people I could be in service to in that. And it was really nice. I didn't begin my my life to towards Sundance until I was older in years.

I was in my 20s when I finally stepped into the circle that way. Do you have any questions?

[Steve] (7:17 - 7:36)

Steve, you're muted. Yeah, thank you. I wanted to ask you, when you were born, would you say that the first language that you heard as an infant was your Lakota language?

Was that the first language spoken to you as a newborn baby?

[Loretta] (7:37 - 8:46)

Yes. Yes. I always have a hesitancy about speaking the language because the English language, because very early on they told us that it's very ambiguous.

And so we have to be very careful how to choose our words and how to how to speak it. And so I must say that when I was in school, I was always flunking English because it was just one of those things that was a whole different train of thought and train of mind for me. But at the same time, you know, my Lakota language, my Oglala Lakota language, it I speak with the with the AI, the AI dialect.

And so it's it's a little bit more defined, I think, in in the way that I understand against the N language or the D language, the dialects. And so for me, it was always lapsing into that. My language just I didn't have to think about it.

I just did it. And I don't remember learning it. I just remember it being a part of my my growing up.

[Steve] (8:47 - 9:25)

Yeah, I think that's such a crucial point that the when the babies began to be born and the first language spoken spoken to them was English, that was the beginning of the end right there, you know, because that effort on the part of the United States to destroy the language, to cut that off, to to engage in linguicide, the intentional killing of

language, the outcome of that was then introducing the newborn infant to the colonizers language first, and then the original language becomes a second language, which is crazy.

Right.

[Loretta] (9:25 - 9:25)

Right.

[Steve] (9:26 - 9:29)

And yeah, what would you add to that?

[Loretta] (9:30 - 15:24)

Well, everything that all of the teachings, the the the teachings for rites of passage, say I was at the tail end of this transition where I still was accessed that rite of passage. So those 14 of us that I was telling you about, you know, we were all I guess we all kind of got lumped together in the community where we were being taught all of these things. Basically, we were the oldest child in our families in some respects.

So I think when teaching, teaching of proper ways to do things like the sacred foods, you know, you're taught about that. You're taught about season, season when these things are grown, you're taught about where they're grown and who you have to share that with. One of the things that we we talk about food sovereignty in that respect is how do we how do we maintain our good health if we can eat properly?

You know, how do we do that? And and with the with along with that, with the introduction to convenience, it was a harsh, harsh way for us to change because we were on the run all the time just taking and eating whatever. So it it bore it took out its time on us.

But to teach these things when the first berry grows in the shale rock, because we lived among the shale rock, the little cliffs in that among the around our area, there is shale rock. And so, you know, you know that things like the rattlesnakes live in in those shale rock areas. So you have to know all of those things.

So we're taken and we're taught all of that. And we're also taught about to share what we have. So on the shale rock in the month of June, before all this climate change happened, there's a little it comes up as a little tree.

Maybe it's got five, five little branches on it. And it only comes up in June. And there's maybe four or five little berries on there.

And they're called Aoyampi, and Aoyampi translates to the first berries of the spring and summer where that transition is the first berries for us. But we like so so we're blessed to go and get those. So we wait for them to to get to that place.

So in June we go down and get them. The other one for that is also Timsila, Timsila are those little tubers that grow only in the month of June. So their flowers come up.

And you can get them. And at the end of June, the flowers go away. And so you can't find them anymore.

You can't get them. So you're taught about seasonal gatherings for food. You're taught about how to stand facing the wind over the berry so that when the wind is coming and it goes over the berry and then passes through you, you can pick those berries and eat them.

You can't just stand any old place to pick those berries. They turn bitter and they turn bitter if you stand in front of the wind. And so that and you're not allowing the wind to go through the berries.

Little things like that really began to make you think about what are the important things that we could be thinking about, because it's teachings in life that we also have to be aware about. We can't take shortcuts in terms of how we're moving in that direction. Having grown up with on the land, the soil, our soil was like gumbo.

It's that half clay, half dirt. And it's really hard to grow food on it. And when we were put on reservations, I think, you know, it was probably with the idea that we're going to be put in the hairiest, worst places that government could find to put us.

Probably hoping to, you know, we can die off or some some kind of idea that way. But what ended up happening is that we understood what all exists on that land so that we could

go out and get prepared for the coming winter. It was always about the season.

It's always about when things grow and when things can be harvested. Medicines, from the time you have the fall equinox and the spring equinox, you can gather and harvest medicine. That's the time you do that.

But on the other side of that, when you hear the thunders, the first time you hear the thunders, usually between February 21st to now, to March 21st, you don't touch medicine. You don't gather medicine anymore. You let it lay fellow so that it can do replenish itself and renew itself, rejuvenate itself.

But those are little lessons that, you know, are part of our principle building teachings. And so that we have we have to abide by those things. But when we came into this age of convenience, we really liked it.

I have to say it was easiest for us to go run to our stepmother's Safeway to pick up food, you know, that you didn't really have to go and forage for. At the same time, you know, there was so much process, so much, you know, things that were processed. And we at the time, we enjoyed what we were enjoying.

But today, you know, some of us are not around anymore because of all of the changes that happened to us in those times.

[Steve] (15:24 - 15:29)

Yeah. So you were born 57 years after the Wounded Knee Massacre.

[Loretta] (15:29 - 15:30)

Yes.

[Steve] (15:30 - 15:33)

And which occurred in December of 1890.

[Loretta] (15:34 - 15:34)

Right.

[Steve] (15:35 - 16:23)

And the. So I think about that because when my friend Virgil Kills Straight. When I met him and I found out he was born in 1940, then I thought, wow, that's only only a few years, 50, 50 years from that.

But then I think of my own grandparents, my Shawnee grandma is an example. And she was born in 1899. Then I think, well, that was only nine years after the Wounded Knee Massacre.

And you'd start thinking in terms of your own family members going back, your own ancestors and and so forth. And you realize all these things that we think about is such a long time ago are pretty recent in terms of all the things that have happened. Right.

[Loretta] (16:24 - 16:26)

It's like two generations. Yes.

[Steve] (16:27 - 16:27)

Say it again.

[Loretta] (16:28 - 16:29)

It's about two generations.

[Steve] (16:30 - 16:49)

Yeah. But so I think I wanted to ask you about the difference in the mental world of Lakota language and the mental world of English and the behaviors that go with those mental worlds. Could you speak a little bit about that?

[Loretta] (16:49 - 23:54)

That's a hard one for sure. But at the same time, you know, the grounding that I have with my language, you know, I was I was knowing that there are things to be said in a short process. The words are important.

Words are really important. And so when we're when we're going to be talking like today for the last few days, I've been really thinking about what I'm going to share with you. And about that.

And so going into the teaching modes of it, you know, it was always the practitioner mode where our grandparents and aunties and so on, they grab us and they say, you're going to learn this, you're going to teach you this. And in a way that's loving and in a way that says to us, this is important. So we would always be there to be able to receive their teachings and receive the words.

And today I see that because of that, never being told to not talk my language, I was never told that. And even though I did go to Catholic school, there was a movement where I saw that they really wanted to know more and more about these medicine people and the works. And I looked at that as a transition from and an opening for we can do some collaboration with the people that we were interacting with as our teachers or that.

But also being aware that my grandparents, when I would come home from school in those years in the 50s and 60s, they would always we would go to ceremony. We would we would go when I was young, my grandpa would write to tribal council meetings. And then when he come home, my grandma's, my aunties, my mom's would all be preparing food because we were going to go to ceremony that night.

Little did I realize that. When you go to tribal council, you need to go to ceremony by the time you come home, you know, at the end of the day, and so they were setting a pattern for us to follow. And and so we would be prepared.

We would load up the wagons and my grandma's would throw the blankets on and I'd be buried in the blankets going to the ceremony five miles away and then back. But his ceremonies were always very full. The entire community members would would come.

We went to him for every illness, for every everything. We didn't go running to the agency clinic for for things. So I grew up very strong using native medicines.

At the same time, when I got introduced to going to Catholic boarding school, we had we lived too far away for buses to come because the roads were not that good anyway. So we had to go find a place to go to school. So the lesser of two evils for for my family, I think, was to for me to go to Catholic boarding school rather than the BIA, because those were the two that were offered the residential schools and the Catholic boarding schools.

Perhaps they were not they were the same in terms of what what the evil part of that was. But at the at the place where I grew up. With the school, when they started to do the mass, the Father John Bride was the Society of Jesus Priest and out of Marquette, Michigan.

And he came and he would do the mass, the entire mass in Lakota, in Oglala language. And so it was a trust factor. He was very proficient in the use of the Oglala language.

And so it when when you talk your language, there's an element of trust that you give and that the people receive it and they give it back to you. There's that that thing is what builds the collaboration of the cooperation or whatever it is that you're going to be in partnership with people. It's how that the words are in between.

So you be very careful about how you use those things. I was telling Peter earlier that my grandparents would say to me, you know, the English language is very ambiguous. They can tell you something and mean something else totally.

So it's not just one way. You have to hear it with an open mind because you need to figure out what is it that they're really saying to you. Like we did when we went to see Bishop Tomasi and he was saying, what is it you want?

You know, and and I thought to myself, my gosh, you know, for all these years, our people have been coming here and they don't hear us, you know, so I think it requires that we have an openness like Peter was willing to let me come on and talk, you know, and you invited me to come and talk with Peter. And I was really looking forward to it because here again is an opportunity for us to have a real candid conversation, as it were. But at the same time, you know, I felt comfortable enough to say, OK, he doesn't really know who I am, but I don't know who he is.

But I'm going to trust that the people who put us together are feeling like we could interact together in a partnership way. So in that way, I can just explain it about that much, because I think it takes a lot. It takes a lot for people to sit together to talk, because sometimes you feel like, is anybody really listening to me?

Is anybody really hearing me? It may not be so simple when I talk about it in my language and it's not and I treat it with respect. But at the same time, with very few words in English, you can say something, but perhaps you're not getting at the heart of it.

So you have to rely on each other. So that reliance, I think, can be built up to be a very strong relational building of people in a community, building towards community again,

you know, always with that in mind, because you're doing things in a relational way. Like I have a relationship with you, you know, for me, it's, you know, whatever it is that you're you're doing, I'm really happy to be a part of it because you're always really strong in how you give teachings and how you talk to people.

So I really enjoy all of that because I learned something from it, too.

[Steve] (23:57 - 25:33)

As you know, I like to emphasize the original free existence of our nations and peoples, extending back to the beginning of time and thinking about the origin stories, the creation stories, such as Virgil would always express and explain to people because he was wanting people to understand the basic principles and the understandings of how things came to be the way that they are. But then that free existence, that system of domination that was brought across the ocean by ship based on those Vatican documents and other such documents, that contrast between the free way of life and people that want to rob our peoples of a free way of life and impose something else on us. And so when you think about that in Lakota, for example, in the documentary movie Oyate Woyaka, The People Speak, Bryant Highhorse remembered as a little boy hearing his elders say, as I recall it, I hope I'm not mispronouncing it, but that's how he taught me to say it and meaning long ago we were free.

And so how do you think about that? How do you express that in Lakota? You had a little bit different way of explaining that in the Lakota language.

[Loretta] (25:34 - 31:27)

I think there was a prayer, maybe not a prayer, but like maybe a poetic way to to identify how we used to be. And in that reference, when you do the prayer part of it, like the formal, then you have to use that language. And so that language that Brian just taught you is really appropriate to that.

And another way to do that is that to get the attention of everybody of every age you start off by saying, and it means back when it used to be, way back when it used to be. Meaning that these things are not just something that we just started today, but back then. And so you have a platform where you've practiced all of these things in just the right measure and just the right way, because we're taught these ways.

We're taught you don't add anything and you don't take anything away. You do it and be taught and share and just the way that you're given those things by your old ones. And so it locks you into a feeling of being safe.

And at the same time, a correct manner, like you're standing up for your people and being in service. You're doing it in a correct manner and that they will lovingly correct you if you step out of line or if you just misstep. You know, they don't berate you and, you know, try to shame you.

We didn't ever have any of that shaming kind of correction, you know. And that all came, the aggressor language, you know, always takes us to that place where there's something violent or that the Native peoples, like for me, that we have to have their authority in order to make something happen. And so for me, it's always like stepping away from that to think that, you know, I wonder who taught them, you know, who gave them the right to be the way they are, to be as mean or as whatever they're presenting.

But I just always respect them to stand and listen, and then I'll say what I have to say about it. But at the same time, you know, I found that to be, we climbed to the mountain in Kogi land, the Kagawa Nation in Colombia one year, and there was this 24-year-old young Kogi leader. He had asked us to sign a commitment to say that the three things that ruin the world, that are in the world, that are causing chaos today are infidelity between a man and a woman, child abuse, sexual abuse of a child, and the third one was homosexuality.

He said that those three things were what are causing the world to be in chaos. There's a way to change, but we have to acknowledge that those are the things. So then I said to him, I said, tell me, I said, have you ever been married?

And he said, no. And I said, have you ever fathered a child? And he said, no.

And I said, were you ever abused as a child? Did anybody ever try to abuse you as a child? He said, no.

So I said, so that you don't know the relationship between men and women, you don't have any knowledge. So I said, how can you in your age, at your age, where you've never experienced any of these, be telling me, I'm 60 some odd years old, and you're telling me that you want me to commit to this, what you believe, when you have never had that experience. And so then he got real angry at me, he said, these are the ways of our people.

And I told him, yes, but you have to learn how to do these things in a way from experience. And only then can you begin to, to let me know that you have compassion, you have, you have the sense for having, working with people so that you can call it what it is then. But today, I'm not going to go along with you.

And I'm not going to sign your paper, because I don't stand with you in that way. So sometimes you have to pull from your own tradition, what that is. And in a lot of what goes on in the world today, you know, there's so much change has happened, that we frown on those who are different.

And the bigger part of that is that the world of the aggressors frown even that much more on everybody, you know, and not accepting that we all have a place in the world. There's that missing component for them. So it's always, it colors, it colors their vision, it colors how they cannot receive something and be joyful in something else, you know.

[Steve] (31:29 - 32:09)

It's, that's, that's a powerful story. Could I ask you about prayer and Lakota language? And what is it the, what, what is it about the Lakota language?

I hope this is the right way of asking the question, but what is it about the Lakota language that seems so perfectly designed for prayer and for deep appreciation of life and, and, and so forth, that those principles of the wope, the seven laws and wola kota principles.

[Loretta] (32:09 - 39:22)

I think that when we recognize that we live, we live in a world where we honor our mother's rematriation throughout everything that we do, we're teaching our, our young women how to appreciate and to hold their life journey in such a way that, you know, allows for substantial growth and things happen really well when women have a leadership place. And that leadership place doesn't necessarily have to be like in government, the way that we see the women and how, how they have that place that they, they can operate from, but it can be that way. We teach our little ones, our young women that the world belongs to us and, and so it's up to us to, to hold that and to take care of it.

And in there we have a program, not a program, but a ceremony called Toss the Ball. And Toss the Ball is a buffalo hide ball made and we put medicines in there for these women to teach them about how to use the medicines, how

to do this, how to do that. At the same time, you know, you're, you're ceremonial.

That's the beginning of this little children's life, this little girl, you know, her life is Ishnuti. You're teaching her how to be alone, how to make decisions, how to have discernment, how to be responsible, how to have everything in that container that she's going to be responsible to take care of. So as you're doing these things, you don't have time to be, you know, doing other, getting involved in other things, but rather, you know, working your, your own life so that you can have things the way you want.

At the same time, you know, there's the other part that there are not going to be enough men in the world for every woman. That's in the teachings. The balance is always going to be more women in the world than there are men.

And so if you have a couple of grandsons, I think you have a couple of grandsons with Shauna, like I have a couple of grandsons. I don't have any granddaughters, but someday I know that I'm going to have to teach these little boys how to be around the women so that when, when someday, when my daughter-in-law gives my grandsons to another woman. So there's a big relationship building that has to happen.

There are all of these pieces of, of the world that we have to take care of from, from the get-go. We're teaching these little girls the rites of passage called Ishnuti, and then we're teaching the boys their rite of passage called Ho-Trohk'echa, changing of the voice. And so within that

context of it, you're identifying there's male and there's female and, and in the prayer of Lakota people, from the way I learned it, is that there's Dakushkashka is the word that we call the all-powerful being, Dakushkashka.

And it doesn't necessarily translate to, to any one thing as much as it is about life. Dakushkashka is everything alive, movement, sacred movement, the great vibration. Some, some refer to that as creator.

And then you have Wo'op'cheh, and Wo'op'cheh translates to the laws of the Oglala women or the laws of Lakota women. And that is that when you're teaching these rites of passage, you're teaching them all these principles and guidelines for those principles and how, how they, they, they are tendered. And that's why I was telling you, we don't add anything or we don't take anything away when we're teaching about prayer.

There's a certain methodology, if you will, that this prayer follows. There are certain words that are used for particular prayers, and there are certain things that are used in those rituals that identify to that. So for the women, they have their, their special medicine bundles that we're building for them in that rites of passage.

For the, for the boys, they also have their medicine bundles that we were filling with the things that they're going to need in their life. One of the young boys came in that we had teach the buffalo kill dance to our little ones, to our little boys. And in that, he was teaching them, you know, going close to the ground and picking up grass and just

kind of throwing it up like buffalo would when they're prowling at themselves.

And he was dancing, but he, at the same time, he was teaching them that. So our little boys were just getting down with, with, with him and snorting and, you know, doing, making the obvious noises and, and things, and then incorporating it into a prayer. And then later on, one of the grandsons came and he said, he said, Oh gee, he said, are we all going to be buffalo, buffalo dancers?

And I said, some of you will probably have a calling. You'll have a vision if you're going to do that, but no, not all of you will be, but you always want to be prepared because at some point there's going to be a spiritual feeling that you're going to get from wherever it's going to come from, for you to participate, to be in service of something. Okay.

And then, so we give them the first thing, the first gift for those young boys, according to my, my tioshpaye, is an eagle bone whistle. And so we got the eagle bone whistles ready for them. And then I was, we, we were in a gathering and I called my grandson over and I said, Takoja, I said, can you, can I have your permission to ask you to blow your eagle bone whistle for me?

So he looked at me and he said, right now? So I said, yeah, right now. So he blew his whistle and the whole room stopped and everybody turned to look where the whistle was being blown.

And I'm already standing there going like this, you know, so he looked at me and he looked at the people. And then he said, oh gee, he said, if ever you need the eagle bone whistle blown, you let me know. I'm your man.

You know, so for me, he got it. I was trying to affect a sacred sound, a sacred calling and a way to, to be not invasive, not to be in people's face. You know, you don't want to, you want to convey things in ways that people want to hear what you're talking about.

[Steve] (39:22 - 39:53)

Hmm. I was so, I was so amazed to find out, I don't know why it seemed so impressive to me, but to find out that that LA sound is a sound of deep affection. And so LA, Kota, Pilamia, Wopila, you know, those, all those types of, so then, then that deep affection is actually built into the language itself, which is the languages and language of deep affection for all of life.

[Loretta] (39:54 - 40:39)

Exactly. Exactly. So when I call you spiritually, I call you Misunkala, you know, my, my little brother, Misunkala are for the women, Mitrunkala, you know, it's a term of endearment.

And so people know when, when they're feeling special, you can make them feel even that much more part of the, whatever it is you're doing by adding LA to it. So thank you for sharing that, because that's an important concept or component. When I call Trakojala, Trakojala, you know, all our, or some Trakojala, you know, great grandchildren,

because we're there now, we're even having great grandchildren come into our midst.

[Steve] (40:40 - 40:43)

Peter, did you have any questions?

[Peter] (40:43 - 46:31)

A lot, I mean, not, not a lot of questions, but a lot of thoughts. I guess Lorraine and I talked just briefly before we put the recording on, and I told her a little bit about what you already know about growing up with my Italian grandparents and aunts and uncles. And that very much echoes the sense of how I learned about family and about the rest of the world.

And I guess I want to say also that I was blessed by the fact that my grandfather was very much anti-Catholic, so we did not get mixed up with all of that. In fact, his, he taught me about a man named Giordano Bruno, who was killed by the Inquisition because he challenged the idea of the church saying that there was, you know, it was the center. And he was saying that the whole universe is, there isn't any center.

It's everywhere. And for that, he got burned alive at the stake. So my grandfather had a very different sense of the long history about who, what does it mean to be alive on this planet and in this universe?

And food, you mentioned food. Food was very important. He had a big garden.

One year he had a thousand tomato plants. He supplied everybody around with tomatoes, and they were a major part of our food all year long because of, you know, the pasta and tomato sauce. And so harvesting tomatoes, planting the tomatoes and everything else that we needed, my grandma would, she spoke the least of English, but she would tell me, go out and get some parsley or go get, you know, what she needed.

And so I always had a connection to like the food and what we ate, the daily life, the annual life, all of that. What I didn't get was the language because I was in that generation where there was a lot of prejudice against Italians. And my grandfather told the rest of the family, don't let him learn Italian.

So they talked Italian, but they wouldn't let me learn it. I could pick up a little bit here and there, but I regret that. But I know that it's part of many people's experience that have been oppressed by various forms of hatred and discrimination that they're to try to erase something of who they are.

So a lot of that connects to me. Another thought, you twice mentioned the word convenience and, you know, how that's a disruptor. And so I quickly looked up the word convenience, and it goes back to the Latin, bring together.

And you think like convene and assembly. So the meaning bringing together, like you bring all the food together into the shop, so it's a convenient store. But the other side of that is that it destroys and separates.

So by bringing together, quote unquote, the items into a store, you've disrupted and broken apart the relationship among people. And where does that food come from? And now where we are, it's not even really food.

I was at the grocery store the other day, and I noticed a box, something crackers or something. And it was called Real Food. So I thought, oh, this interesting brand name.

And it has that image like, oh, this is healthy. So I took the box off the shelf, and it has all these chemical ingredients in it. And it reminds me of Philip Deere talking about how we put stuff in our mouth, and you look at what's on the box.

Those words, you have no idea what they mean. And they go clear across the box, but you're still eating them. So there's so much deception in that world that makes things, quote, convenient, that actually disrupts life.

And I'm not going to quit going to the grocery store. I don't have really an alternative for food, basically. But if I keep my mind open and my heart open when I'm there, I can make a connection to the people that are working there, and I can pay attention to what is real food and what is not real food.

And I bring it home and cook it so that I'm involved with all of that process. So I'm just reflecting on how your words affect me and make me remember my life and who I am. And I guess just one last thing is you and Steve talking and

Steve asking about the difference between Lakota and English.

And it seems to me one of the major things is the relationality of language. And within English, so much of it is really abstract. That's why you need a dictionary.

Like, what does that word mean? Oh, I better look up that word. And the word is not immediately obvious.

It doesn't feel like it's a word that's connected to the earth or the sky or the wind or any real thing. It's connected to a realm of ideas, of words. And it's easy, then, why people fall into talking in ways that they have no experience, like that man you were talking about, because people have ideas or opinions about something.

Well, what have you experienced? You have said, well, I studied about this. Oh, but so you never actually experienced anything about that.

No, no, but I read about it. And I read the experts, that kind of thing. And so where is your actual knowledge?

Where are your feet on the ground, you know, in relation to what your knowledge is? Well, for many, many people, probably most people in this so-called civilized world, it doesn't come from that. It doesn't come from actual life.

[Steve] (46:32 - 47:50)

It's only those thoughts that are triggered. That turns out that that company you're talking about, the food company, the full name is Real Weird Food. Yeah, yeah.

It's extraordinary to find out, very disturbing to find out how much of what we take for granted to be food is some bizarre thing that they can use to manipulate everyone and make more money, more profit. And it's just really sad, really, when you think about the sacredness of, or even the idea of a sacred connection between the earth and ourselves by means of the plants and so forth and the different types of food. And in fact, the way in which you, Loretta, create the sacred foods for the ceremonies and all that goes into that.

I mean, this is just an extraordinary responsibility that the women have that you folks carry out. And then some people don't even seem to appreciate it. It's kind of like, yeah, that disturbs me when I see that there's not that deep appreciation for the role that you still try to maintain up to this time.

[Loretta] (47:50 - 51:16)

I know. Recently I heard somebody ask about why do we have to have it? It's a soothing measure from the women when you can feed your ones who are coming together to meet or to do whatever.

But it's beyond that because you're praying about that food and you're praying with it as you're preparing. It's food that's been prepared a year ahead of time. So we have, the way that that's set up, you have the water is for the winter

and then you have the corn is for the spring and then you have the berries, the choke cherries for the summer and the buffalo meat for the fall.

When I tell that story about people and wanting them to nourish themselves spiritually, physically and spiritually, emotionally, a lot of the women who we meet with will cry when they eat that food because they said, we used to have this. We used to have sacred food and I say to them, and you can again, you can have it again. And so it causes a switch back to a place where it used to be good for them.

It used to be this way for them, positive. And so that's why when we go to meetings, we bring our sacred food so that our people can feel that feeling again and that participatory manner and the relationship that we have with each other and sitting together and actually having some good words to come in between all of us, you know, so it's like that. And then I also tell about the sharing part of that, our grandmas and grandpas told us when you go and pick choke cherries from the choke cherry tree, you leave the top for the birds, you only pick from the middle and you leave the bottom for the little snakes and the little critters that also like choke cherries.

So it's a sharing method whereby you're ensuring that you're taking care to be in service even to your other relatives. And that prayer that goes from Makota, it starts in the universe, then it starts to the sun, you know, to sun and to this air, this firmament, the earth's mother, the rock that sits at the center of the earth and in our creation story and the fire and the water and the moon, those are the ways in

which we line up our prayers. And so it's like I was telling you, there's specific ways that we're taught to do this, this and this and don't change anything, don't add anything.

So that's always been the way that we continue to do that, to be in service to that. Laying down, sharing, you know, if you don't, to be all inclusive, you know, you're always wanting to make relatives, you're always looking to make relatives. And the way to do that is to share like we're doing today.

[Steve] (51:18 - 53:23)

There's, it just, it's so extraordinary to me to think about the time of our ancestors before those people came across the ocean by ship and there were no pesticides, there were no chemicals to poison everything. And then to, I was recently noticing a podcast by the podcaster, Joe Rogan, and he was interviewing Robert Kennedy Jr. as the secretary of health and human services. And they were talking about the glyphosate and the extent to which that's in the food.

And Bobby Kennedy Jr. said, well, he made a statement to paraphrase that basically the entire U.S. food system is reliant on this pesticide, this poison. And it's extraordinary to think about that. So they've taken what the sacred food and they've contaminated everything.

And a lot of these are for, they even have a term called forever chemicals, meaning they're never going to go away. So to me, there's a kind of an insanity. There's a type of a madness that is endemic and just intrinsic to the whole nature of their domination system.

And then how do you, how do you get away from it? You know, once, so that's why what you're doing and the things that you're maintaining, that you've managed to hold together, you and other traditional folks that have maintained your ways is so crucial to the planet, is absolutely crucial to the planet. And so I want to thank you and just say how much I admire your commitment and the way of life that you have upheld and maintained based on your upbringing.

And it's just a beautiful thing to see. And I very always think very fondly of you and how honored I am to have you as a friend.

[Peter] (53:25 - 54:44)

Well, I'm going to ask Loretta, you know, I know we're getting near the end of the hour, but I have a question. I think it's a hard question. So people talk about relearning languages.

And my friend, Jessie Littledome, Ashby Wampanoag woman, has done a lot of work with, you know, recovering the language there. And she's had, she's been working at it for a while. But it's a question is like, to me, it seems like she has to start with the Bible that I forget one of the famous missionaries there created a Bible.

And he wrote the English and the Wampanoag. He put, tried to write the sound of Wampanoag. So she discovered that.

She said, well, maybe that will be a clue to getting back into the Wampanoag language. So that's incredible work. But she still is having to start with that English.

So it seems to me that there's that problem is that if anybody is trying to learn a language which is so completely different from English, it's not like Spanish or French or German that's related. It's completely unrelated. It's like a whole different universe.

It's in a different universe. What are your thoughts about? Is it even possible to do this reclamation?

Just what are your thoughts on that?

[Loretta] (54:45 - 1:01:33)

You know, I was thinking about some of the people who have been involved in that and knowing that their work is now centered around their own families and it's growing. But if you have one speaker, you know, you almost need to sit down with your own family members and begin there. And then it starts to reach out.

But they've been speakers. They've been teachers for, you know, 50 years of the language. And so we still have some people like in our Oglala people language base, we still have people who are still fluent and are always happy to teach.

And so those are the people that I've relied on to come into our Rites of Passage program and to begin working with our little ones. Because we know that English is really

prevalent among a lot of our Native people's ways. They don't use the natural language anymore.

And so we have to preserve it some way. And one of the things I'm doing recently is they're going to have an AI summit in Paris, France, I think April 14th through the 17th. And it's on Indigenous culture.

And I want to see, I want to know what is it that they're doing. And I talked to Steve about this earlier about AI and that how that can affect what it is we're trying to preserve our languages with. Because one of the things that happened, I was praying and they recorded me through this AI process.

And what came out was a jumbled curse words. It was terrible. And I was thinking, you know, they still don't have our Lakota language embedded in their encryption or their cell service, whatever it is that they're using to record.

So that it's still fresh for us to be able to understand how this thing is working. Maybe there is a way to turn it to use it, just like everything that you can learn. But there is no, how do you step into it relationally?

So we've been reaching out across different ones because they're talking about policy, they're talking about, you know, maybe setting up a way to, it gets into intellectual property and all of those kinds of details, you know, that we should be well aware of. We should, we have in our own native ways, we have all of these things. But then again, in a relational way, we're sharing a lot of it.

And so I think that hopefully we can come to some place where we're all working together so it doesn't begin to have the colonizer type effort in coming in and taking our ways. We want to be able to be there to talk about that and to have our say about it, have our own policies. That's what I'd like to think about.

It's, we're on the cutting edge of it right now. And I think a lot of the programming, like I serve on a board of directors for Running Strong for American Indian Youth. And one of the components that we've been funding is language, language retention or restoration.

And the Yuchi languages, we've been working with them for like 30 years and they only had like one or two language speakers. And now their children are playing and talking in the language on the playgrounds. You know, it's like their first language again.

So there's hope in it. The Mohawks here also have a language nest. They have a baby nest of language.

And so from the time those little ones are coming in, I don't know, maybe a year old or even younger, the mothers are invited to come in and bring their children in so that the teachers are working with these babies along with the mothers and the families, teaching them cooking. They have the hominy corn, which we use in our sacred food because it isn't tainted. It's not changed.

I guess the big seed companies try to come in and change it, hybridize it, and they couldn't do it. So that's the corn that I use in our sacred food preparation. We use, try to have organic buffalo meat.

We try to get our berries close to the mountains so that it's free of disease. So there's ways and means to do things, but it takes time, your precious time to go and drive clear to Wyoming, to the mountains to pick cherries or to do whatever you do. Or you buy the buffalo meat, the careful, careful raised buffalo meat.

And then you have to sit and dry that. So for a year ahead of time, it requires that we be prepared all the time. So at any given time, no matter what it is, the medicine people always tell us, you make sure you have all the components for sacred food in your home all the time.

Whatever that sacred food translates to you as a people, make sure you have it. So there's, you know, saying in that relationship building that we need to be mindful. We don't have all the answers.

And all I know is that I'm hanging desperately onto my language. And when my grandson asked me, how do you say dinosaur in our language? And I said, and so he said, then he came back and he said, I know is how you say dinosaur.

How do you say Tyrannosaurus Rex? And I said, you got me there. I don't know.

But, you know, it's working with your loved ones, working with, and we should have a loved one everywhere. You know, we should be able to transcend and the language we should, it's, you know, it's still, it's still, we're still free to use it. So I think it's a component that, you know, if we can put that out to people, how important that language uses that, that the words that we use become better initiated, you know.

Thank you so much guys for.

[Steve] (1:01:33 - 1:01:37)

Yes. Thank you. I hope we can do it again sometime.

[Loretta] (1:01:37 - 1:01:40)

Oh, please. I'd be happy to join you again. This is so profound.

[Peter] (1:01:41 - 1:01:43)

Yes. Thank you very, very much.

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